

Chapter 2 - Moon Roses

The lights on the first floor had long been extinguished, leaving everything pitch black, but Feng Yue's movements in the darkness were not hindered at all.

This was the home she had personally decorated. She was familiar with everything here—even without a single light, she could move around freely.

Feng Yue looked at the guest room key lying quietly in her palm. After a long moment of hesitation, she still didn't take it upon herself to open the guest room door.

She lowered her eyes, put the key away, and then walked toward the dining room.

Feng Yue stopped in front of the dining table, looking at the mess on the floor by the cold moonlight streaming through the window.

She stepped forward and picked up the scattered bouquet of roses. Many petals had fallen off, and some had even been trampled and were somewhat wilted.

Actually, she didn't like roses. It was only because this bouquet was from Yan Lin that it became different from other roses.

Feng Yue simply cleaned it up and put it back in the glass vase on the dining table, but no matter how she arranged it, she felt the bouquet no longer looked beautiful.

Feng Yue stared blankly at the somewhat damaged bouquet, but her mind was on her relationship with Yan Lin.

They had met when they were fourteen, and it was from that time that Feng Yue had fallen in love with Yan Lin.

She felt that this one-sided love that had lasted twelve years was time to end.

She should have understood long ago—a heart that couldn't be warmed after twelve years of trying probably truly didn't belong to her.

She had stolen two years of time that didn't belong to her. She should be content, and Yan Lin should be returned to someone else.

Feng Yue looked at the untouched food on the table, and finally dumped it all into the trash can, while the dishes and chopsticks were moved to the kitchen sink.

Looking at the dining room restored to its original state, Feng Yue showed a bitter smile. This was probably how their relationship would be from now on—clean and neat, with no more intersection.

Early the next morning, Feng Yue was woken by sounds from downstairs. She looked at the time—5 AM.

She remembered that starting from this day, she and Yan Lin had begun a cold war that lasted several months, during which neither had contacted the other first.

Although she had experienced this once before, going through it again still felt very uncomfortable.

But she knew that it was best for them not to see each other right now.

She didn't know if her rebirth would still result in terminal illness and death like in her previous life. If there was no chance to reverse this, then she still had too many things to do.

This time, she wouldn't waste all her time on Yan Lin anymore. She didn't want to regret it again.

As written in that novel, Yan Lin was the protagonist, and she was cannon fodder¹. They were never meant to be together.

But to say she truly had no feelings for Yan Lin anymore was impossible. Twelve years of emotion wasn't something that could be easily cast aside.

Feng Yue lay on her back in bed, hearing the rustling sounds from downstairs, looking at the familiar ceiling.

Her mind was on her upcoming arrangements.

When she woke up yesterday, she had noticed her head hurt badly, and this pain was all too familiar to her.

It turned out that the brain cancer from her previous life had shown symptoms from this time, but back then she hadn't paid any attention to it.

She needed to schedule a full-body checkup.

It wasn't until the sounds downstairs gradually disappeared that Feng Yue closed her eyes again and fell back asleep exhaustedly.

She was too tired. She had experienced too many things yesterday.

Feng Yue slept until 11 AM, until Dai Shuangshuang's phone call woke her up.

"Hello."

"Sister Yue Yue, do you want to go shopping today?"

The girl's voice on the phone sounded energetic and lively, but when Feng Yue thought about what had happened to Dai Shuangshuang in her previous life, her mind immediately became much clearer.

She quickly said: "Shuangshuang, I'm feeling a bit unwell, and your cousin is also away on business. Why don't you come to my house to keep me company?"

The girl sounded anxious upon hearing this: "You're not feeling well? Should I bring a doctor over?"

"No need, just have the driver bring you over directly."

"Okay, I'll come right over."

"Mm, I'll wait for you."

Only after hanging up the phone did Feng Yue finally breathe a sigh of relief.

Dai Shuangshuang was the daughter of Yan Lin's mother's sister. Mother Yan usually had a close relationship with her sister, so Dai Shuangshuang also had a good relationship with Yan Lin and Feng Yue.

The young girl had just graduated this year and was currently unemployed, so she would occasionally invite Feng Yue to go out and have fun.

But Feng Yue remembered that in her previous life, she hadn't agreed to Dai Shuangshuang's invitation because of issues with Yan Lin, and then Dai Shuangshuang had been dragged by some unsavory friends to attend a party at a remote small manor.

It was on this very day that Dai Shuangshuang was kidnapped on her way home from that party.

What followed was nothing more than calling the police, demanding ransom, and so on, but those inhumane kidnappers had sexually assaulted Dai Shuangshuang.

The young girl had been left with psychological trauma. Although she continued to see a psychologist afterward, the treatment wasn't very effective.

Feng Yue had never seen that brilliant smile on her face again.

Feng Yue sat up from the bed and organized her chaotic thoughts. She didn't know if she could prevent Dai Shuangshuang from having an accident, but at least she had to try.

No matter what, Dai Shuangshuang was like a little sister to her, and she didn't want Dai Shuangshuang to end up like in her previous life.

When Dai Shuangshuang arrived at Feng Yue's house, it was around 11:30. She got out of the car carrying several bags in both hands.

"Sister Yue Yue, I thought you definitely hadn't eaten yet, so I went to my family's restaurant to pack some food for you—all things you usually like to eat. Of course, there are also some lighter options. You can see which one you want to eat."

Dai Shuangshuang familiarly carried the bags all the way to the dining room. When she saw the somewhat wilted roses in the vase on the table, she said somewhat strangely: "This bouquet should be changed. Didn't Aunt Liu come this morning?"

The Aunt Liu that Dai Shuangshuang mentioned was the woman who usually took care of their daily needs. She wasn't a live-in housekeeper, just someone who came every day to clean.

The dishes that Feng Yue had put in the kitchen sink last night had been cleaned up by Aunt Liu this morning.

As for this bouquet of flowers...

It should be that Aunt Liu saw how happy she looked when she received the flowers yesterday, so she didn't throw them away.

Feng Yue walked from the living room toward the dining room. When she saw Dai Shuangshuang's familiar smile, she felt somewhat dazed for a moment.

In her previous life, she had often visited Dai Shuangshuang after her accident, but after being diagnosed with cancer, she could barely protect herself.

Seeing that Feng Yue didn't look well, Dai Shuangshuang took it upon herself to open the bag with the lighter food. The moment the lid was lifted, the aroma of the food instantly filled Feng Yue's nostrils.

In her previous life, after getting sick, she ate nutritional meals every day. She hadn't had food with such complete color, aroma, and taste for a long time.

"You sit down and eat together too." Feng Yue went to the kitchen to get two sets of utensils.

Dai Shuangshuang nodded while chattering away, expressing concern about Feng Yue's physical condition: "Sister Yue Yue, what's wrong with you? Should I go with you to the hospital?"

Dai Shuangshuang truly loved Feng Yue and genuinely saw her as an older sister.

Feng Yue took a sip of lean meat congee² and shook her head: "No need. I just didn't rest well last night, so I feel a bit uncomfortable."

As she spoke, she recalled this sensation of her mouth watering from the taste—she hadn't experienced it for a long time.

"Okay, as long as you're fine. Shall we go shopping this afternoon?" Dai Shuangshuang hadn't been shopping for a long time and was now feeling somewhat restless.

Feng Yue was still thinking about the kidnapping case, so when she heard Dai Shuangshuang wanted to go out shopping, she became extremely alert.

So she smiled and said: "Not today. The old mansion sent over some flowers, and you can help me organize them this afternoon. The conservatory hasn't had new additions for a long time."

Dai Shuangshuang thought about it and nodded in agreement: "Okay, then I won't go home today. Cousin isn't home, right?"

"She's away on business."

"That's good then."

The two chatted casually. When the meal was almost finished, Feng Yue put down her chopsticks, wiped her mouth, and asked: "Shuangshuang, I remember you mentioned before that you have a friend who's a lawyer, right?"

Dai Shuangshuang nodded and also took a tissue to wipe her mouth: "Mm, that's right. I remember he works at a fairly famous law firm in the city. Sister Yue Yue, is there something you need?"

"Give me his contact information. I have some legal questions I need to consult about recently."

"Sure, I'll talk to him later and then give you his WeChat."

This topic passed just like that, and Dai Shuangshuang didn't even think about why Feng Yue would need to find a lawyer.

The reason Feng Yue was looking for a lawyer was that her divorce from Yan Lin would be complicated and involve many things, so she needed to start preparing in advance.

After lunch, the two rested for a while before going to the conservatory. The conservatory was mostly filled with moon roses³, because these were Feng Yue's favorite flowers.

There were many varieties of moon roses, and Feng Yue's conservatory only contained a few types she particularly liked—all classic varieties in several colors.

The batch delivered today was a batch of dark red Lincoln roses that she had specifically asked someone to order for her.

These dark red moon roses looked passionate yet flamboyant, a variety that Feng Yue really liked.

Dai Shuangshuang didn't understand these things. Looking at the newly delivered flowers, she just casually said: "Such beautiful flowers. This color feels quite similar to roses."

The speaker was unintentional, but the listener took it to heart.

Feng Yue certainly wouldn't blame Dai Shuangshuang for saying this, but these words were deeply imprinted in her heart.

No matter how similar moon roses were to true roses, they ultimately weren't roses.

Perhaps Yan Lin had also made a mistake. In her heart, she didn't actually like this moon rose at all—it was just that the true rose that belonged to Yan Lin hadn't appeared yet.

The conservatory was designed with transparent glass, so the blazing July sun was almost directly overhead in the afternoon. Dai Shuangshuang was originally a pampered young lady, so naturally, she couldn't stand staying in the conservatory for too long in the heat.

Seeing this, Feng Yue also stood up from the ground, preparing to go back and rest with Dai Shuangshuang, and wait until the sun wasn't so strong later to continue organizing.

But before Feng Yue could successfully stand up, she felt a stabbing pain in her head, and then everything went black as she fainted.

Just before losing consciousness, she heard Dai Shuangshuang's anxious and helpless shouts.

Footnotes:

¹ Cannon fodder (炮灰) - A Chinese internet/novel term referring to minor characters who exist mainly to die or suffer, often to advance the plot or make the main characters look better. They're considered expendable.

² Lean meat congee (瘦肉粥) - A traditional Chinese rice porridge made with lean pork, often served to people who are sick or recovering as it's easy to digest and nutritious.

³ Moon roses (月季) - Also known as Chinese roses or modern garden roses. In Chinese, there's a distinction between 月季 (moon roses/Chinese roses) and 玫瑰 (true roses). The metaphor here is that Feng Yue sees herself as a moon rose trying to be a true rose for Yan Lin.